

On
the Concept, Nature,
and Essence of Philosophy.

A Presentation of
the Propaedeutic of Philosophy.

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Preface.

Had I not, up to now, let every writing of mine that has come forward independently in the literature be accompanied by a preface—not exactly because I have expressly reckoned such a thing among the proper appointments of a book, but because each time it has felt natural to me—I should this time have been inclined to dispense with any preface at all, since I had nothing to say that could be its subject. For the truth is that I would rather have refrained from expressly declaring that what several of my readers will perhaps expect to find stated here I mean to leave to them to settle for themselves. I mean this: in what relation the present writing stands to my book *Om Erkjendelse og Granskning* [On Cognition and Inquiry], published at the close of the year 1821. If I am to declare myself on the matter—for how I intend to use both writings in my lectures on the propaedeutic of philosophy [Philosophiens Propædeutik] does not belong here to explain—then, so far as the public is concerned, I would say nothing more than this: I could wish that, in its relation to the present book, the reader would regard that earlier one as though it were by another author, one whom I had drawn upon and to whom I had therefore often referred, while yet having a different object before me than he. For in that earlier work the object is science [Videnskab] and scientific study in general, and it is offered as an introduction to academic study at large. Here, by contrast, I have had philosophy in particular before me, and have therefore had more to enter into with respect to *this* than had come forward in that other work. —Finally, I ask that among the errata [Rettelser], those marked **NB** in particular may be heeded.

Copenhagen, the 28th of October 1843.

Sibbern.

Preliminary Remarks.

§ 1.

What is to be undertaken here, and where we set out from.

It is the concept, nature, and essence of philosophy that we shall here seek to clarify for ourselves. We cannot, then, confine ourselves to the question: What is meant by philosophy? but have to do with the far more telling question: What is philosophy? Yet we must of course, straightaway and from the very first, take account of the word's meaning, attending to what is called philosophy—and has through the course of history been so called, and has asserted itself under that name. For although the concept we are to seek to give is to be developed and determined as reflection on the matter itself demands, still the question—whether what is thereby set up corresponds to what one calls philosophy, or whether perhaps, with all the validity it may have in and for itself, it is something quite other than what one has in view by the word philosophy—can only be settled by taking into consideration the meaning with which this name passes and holds good. By the name, the object to be spoken of is pointed out, and one must from the first take care not to end up speaking of some other object instead of this one. It is most correct, then, to set out from a given representation [Forestilling] of what philosophy is—a given meaning of the word.

But the matter itself, thus pointed to by the name and thereby lifted out for us, we must then surely consider entirely as it wills to be seen, and must pursue it through its whole consequence, so that the concept, further on, cannot be bound to, nor in its whole carrying-through be conditioned by, that given representation.

In this way we do indeed come to consider philosophy in philosophy's own light, and thus come to lay our own philosophy at the foundation; for we are now to philosophize our way to the cognition [Erkjendelse] we seek, and in all philosophizing philosophy at once asserts itself. But this circularity is a consequence of the whole position of the matter; for philosophy is but one member within the world-totality [Verdenstotalitet] which philosophy itself—according to the concept of it that we must presuppose as given—is to clarify for us.

Note 1. There naturally arises here the question whether the concept of philosophy ought not to be treated in two quite different places: first, in the considerations introductory to philosophy, where the philosophical undertaking cannot of course be dealt with without laying at

its foundation a concept of what philosophy is; —and second, in the very midst of philosophy's system, once the speculative fundamental cognition [Grunderkjendelse] has been so far attained and developed that philosophy—stepping forward as a co-engaging member in the spiritual life unfolding in consciousness—comes to be considered from the speculative—more precisely a psycho-biological—standpoint. One readily sees that, although philosophy would lead us back to the first fundamental moments and beginning (*initia*) of all things, it nevertheless itself belongs in the very midst of the world's course, where it can first arise in the higher life of consciousness, or in the midst of the sphere of spirituality, and must then show itself as an essential principal moment in the totality of spiritual life. The question of philosophy's proper essence [Væsen] belongs, then, there where poetry, morality, and religiosity too are to constitute themselves for us in their essential belonging-together with the totality of spiritual life. —

The question then naturally arises whether we ought not to distinguish, from this spirit-philosophical and properly speculative consideration of philosophy's essence, another, preliminary one belonging to a mere introduction to philosophy—which we might then call the merely propaedeutic, and which would at the same time be called the merely explicative. This one would merely pursue the given concept of philosophy through all its consequence and thereafter determine and expound it, whereas the other would let philosophy itself constitute itself for us and thereby show itself in its proper essence. This last would then be the one which, if the very expressive designation the philosophy of philosophy is to be adopted, would have to be furnished with that name.

Yet to such a merely propaedeutic exposition of the concept of philosophy we neither can nor will here confine ourselves, nor keep it separated from the speculative; for it is philosophy itself—not the concept that has formed about it—that we have before us here, and the clarification of philosophy, if it is to be complete, cannot rest at that merely propaedeutic level.

In the meantime we must surely seek constantly to remain aware how far our concept, as it more and more determines and develops itself for us, remains within the domain [Gebeet] of the merely propaedeutic—so that it can be set up as valid with respect to the various philosophical parties (Platonists, Skeptics, Kantians, Lockians, and so forth), and can thus be laid at the foundation in the history of philosophy—and how far, on the other hand, it goes further, and so is already developed according to the dictate of a definite philosophical fundamental view [Grundanskuelse].

Note 2. One will readily see that it would be altogether inappropriate to give the first and fundamental part of philosophy itself—which Hegel has called Logic—the name of the philosophy of philosophy, as some have done. Hegel, too, is very far from having been able to give any occasion for this, since with him the philosophy of philosophy—though this name is not found in him—appears at the close of the third and last part of his whole system.

Note 3. Concerning the expression *nature and essence* and its relation to the expression *concept*, be it noted that what is here most immediately and first sought is the concept of philosophy and

its exact determination, but that this concept is then to unfold itself for us, or to step out into the whole sum-total [Indbegreb] of its consequence, or into its whole content—which is what we have in view by the expression *nature and essence*. (I refer here to my *Logik*, § 35.)

§ 2.

A survey of the whole course of what follows.

If, then, we ask first of all: What does one understand by philosophy?—whereby we are only to indicate provisionally just so much that we may know with certainty what it is that is to be treated, but must also at once come to indicate the first points to which we have to direct our attention—then we note that the received concept implies that philosophy is to aim at a certain fundamental cognition [Grunderkjendelse] serving for a deeper clarification of the whole of existence [Tilværelse], but that it is to form itself through thinking and reflection, and thus to become a cognition that is to be aware of its own inner groundedness and able to give an account of it. In this way, then, we come to let our consideration take the following course:

First and foremost we take into consideration that 1) philosophy is a whole body of cognizing [Indbegreb af Erkjenden], and we therefore consider the nature and essence of cognition in general.

Next we observe that, since philosophy aims at a certain deeper fundamental cognition that looks toward the last or innermost fundamental relations [Grundforhold]—yet such a cognition shows itself as philosophy only when it comes forward as sprung from rational cognition [Fornufterkjendelse], and especially only when investigation [Efterforskning] or inquiry [Randsagelse] has thereby been set in motion—we are hereby led to consider the endeavor of cognition in general in its transition from its first principal stage, the stage of first, immediate cognizing, to its second principal stage, the mediated but at the same time higher stage of cognizing called forth by the spirit of inquiry [Randsagelsesaand]—the stage at which cognition becomes a cognizing according to insight, and at the same time—since here testing must take place, an account must be rendered, grounds come under consideration, and groundedness is brought to light and made good—a cognition in force of grounds [i Kraft af Grunde]; which then lets us see philosophy as that which 2) is a whole body of intelligent and rational cognizing.

To this attaches, further, the observation that, since this whole body must form a well-connected totality [Heelhed], philosophy in its carrying-through and execution must become 3) a scientific cognition—whereby we are brought to consider science [Videnskab] and scientific character [Videnskabelighed] in general.

But since—according to the received concept—not all scientific cognizing is philosophy, then, by asking ourselves what sort of science it is in which philosophy consists, we come to become aware that the endeavor to press through to the grounds cannot but lead to the forming of 4) a *science* that in a certain *all-comprehending manner* aims at ultimate grounds and an ultimate fundamental cognition, and that it is this above all that one has in view when one speaks of philosophy; and here, when the question is now raised whether it is the ultimate grounds and fundamental relations of all cognition, or of the whole of existence, that are thereby meant, it will appear that—although a twofold principal task [Hovedopgave] for philosophy has in this respect formed, and had to form—it is nevertheless in the end only 5) the ultimate grounds and fundamental relations of *existence*, or as one is wont to say, of *all things*, in the finding-out and cognition of which the all-comprehending fundamental cognition is to form, wherein philosophy consists.

This determination of the concept of philosophy, handed down from ancient times, from which we are thus brought to set out, shows us philosophy as that which comes forward over against, and in a certain opposition to, the sum-total of all that cognizing whereby everything is given us and presents itself to us—everything whose ultimate grounds and fundamental relations are now to be in question, and which we are accordingly prompted and called upon to gather for ourselves into a single overview.

In its pursuit through the various principal respects or principal directions, we shall next see the concept of philosophy lead to a whole cycle of conceptual determinations, which can be developed into a whole cycle of definitions.

Thereupon we shall proceed to consider philosophy in its execution. But when we now first take into consideration what ultimate grounds are, and how matters stand with our pressing toward them, the question of philosophy's foundation [Grundlag] and starting-point will prove to have to precede the question of the execution of philosophy's work—to which, then, once we have thereupon fully answered for ourselves the question what philosophy is, a consideration of philosophy's significance in the totality of existence will naturally be able to succeed.

With this, the course we shall take is fully indicated.

Note. It must be noted here at once—what will be more closely treated further on in its place—that alongside philosophy proper, of which alone there is question here, there is a whole body of sciences which, without being philosophy proper, are nevertheless also called philosophical, but which I, to distinguish them from the former (see further on, § 11), give the name of explicative philosophy, and to which I here pay no regard whatever.

Introductory Considerations.

On Cognition in General.

§ 3.

Philosophy is a) cognition. —The fundamental moments of all cognition.

All cognizing aims at an *is*, whereby something, in asserting itself in us, is posited by us as an objective [det Objective] to which we must ascribe validity, and which, insofar as it comes forward for us in this its validity, we call the true—which is then to be taken entirely as it gives itself to us, that is: shows itself to be.

Here, then, we see an opposition [Modsætning] between a self-conscious subjectivity and an objectivity subsisting independently of it—one which, moreover, comes forward for us not only from without but also from within. But cognition sets in only when this opposition is so overcome that what is comes forward for the subjectivity too exactly as it is, so that it comes to be for us—that is, is posited by us to be—just as it is in itself; whereby we come, in the very act of living in our own individual subsistence, at the same time to live in the fullness of objectivity, indeed of the true.

The mediating and unifying element between the true and the subjectivity—which latter shows itself at the same time as an individuality—is, on the side of the first, the determining necessity with which it asserts itself, and on the side of the subjectivity it is *partly* the latter's becoming-determined and the coming-to-consciousness that thereby sets in, which may be called a receiving (*scimus, quia accepimus*), *partly* the individual life's own doing that answers to that becoming-determined. —But this last is again partly one that aims merely at a directing of the mind [Sindshenvendelse], partly one that aims at inner subjective re-presentation and objectification. In the first we see a subjective reaction and response, called forth by the awakening power of the determining influence, that aims merely to make the reception deeper and fuller—both through an accompanying devotion and through a supervening recollection—as a care that the true may, in all its points and relations, come to its rightful full power in us, so that in each and all we may be determined wholly in accordance with the true's own bearing. In the subjective re-presentation and objectification, by contrast, we see a productivity springing from the individual life itself, which has its inner ground and mode of activity within itself, and now, as a producing doing, brings forth and constitutes within the subjective self-consciousness the inner presentation, in and through which the true

comes to be taken up into the subjective life. (And here, properly, it is first said: *scimus, quia facimus*. —For the rest I refer here to my work *Om Erkjend. og Granskn.*, §§ 1–3, as well as to my *Psychologie*.) But what makes it that in our own productivity we nonetheless have, not something merely subjective, but—by means of and through this merely subjective—the true itself, is the power with which the true so determines and governs the subjective life that creates and forms the representation, that it thereby at the same time presents itself as the valid for the self-conscious beholding.

Note 1. When we here speak of an “is,” we see here not only an opposition between an “is” and an “is-not,” but also an opposition between an “is” and a “shows itself” or “seems.” Hereupon one may at once ask whether this “seems” too must not be said to be, and conversely, whether an “is” can ever be anything other than a “shows itself.” Here it would be a matter of asking what that “is” really means; and when we then observe that we can in general have to do only with a being insofar as it asserts itself, but that now every seeming too asserts itself, then the question is whether there is here a differing self-assertion, and on what such difference rests—whereby a difference between a merely momentary and subjective and a more constant and objective self-assertion may perhaps be assumed, and within the latter there may again be distinguished a) a merely sporadic, b) a merely microcosmic, c) a macrocosmic validity, and only the last is to be acknowledged as the properly true one in the last instance. But here the consideration would arise that all apparent, all sporadic, all microcosmic self-assertion must in the end be grounded in the macrocosmic order of things, so that here it is to be noted that all that other self-assertion is seen in its true light—that is, in its proper being—only by being seen in its emergence from, and reducibility to, the macrocosmic order of things. —But all the considerations that might thus be called forth by reflection on that “is” do not belong here, but to the fundamental considerations of speculative philosophy itself. —This much is certain: that throughout all our striving for cognition, the opposition between an “is” and a “seems”—an “in itself” and a “not in itself”—and along with it the opposition between an objective and a subjective, so asserts itself that in the whole course of our cognizing, as in the whole of the rest of our life bound up with it, we cannot withdraw ourselves from it. And to this we hold ourselves here, where we have merely to expound the nature of cognition as it gives itself to us, and where we take without further ado the existence of a cognizing, with all the moments therein, as given—just as we take the existence of a philosophy as given—without entering here into the question of the proper reality of all cognition and all philosophy, which it belongs to speculative philosophy itself to decide. —The concept of cognition we have here given has plainly—this is still to be noted—validity even for one who would deny all our cognizing any true reality; for such a one too must nonetheless have a concept of cognition that he lays at the foundation, and it can only be the one given here; and one who would ascribe to all our cognizing only a certain subjective validity must still admit that cognition rests on the agreement of our representing with something that takes on the character

of an objective.

Note 2. As an “is” forms itself, intelligence at once intervenes, and a so-called category—or better, an a priori fundamental determination—asserts itself. Herewith cognition too at once comes forward as that which issues in a judging, whereby a something (as subject) comes forward as that which is something definite (the fundamental determination of whatness), and this what-it-is comes forward as an other, which is nonetheless, by the judging itself, made one with the former (as predicate). This fundamental nature of judging is expressed in the so-called principle of identity.

Note 3. The question arising here—how that productivity, having its inner ground and mode of activity, and hence also the regulative principle for it, within itself, nonetheless comes to present a real objective—is of speculative nature, and finds for us its answer in the Idea of a *harmonia originaria* between individuality and totality. The determining influence of the objective is indeed only an eliciting one, since it is the individual life itself that, by its own activity within the individuality’s circle of consciousness, brings about that whereby the objective is to become the cognized. But just as the whole individuality first comes forth at all through the total course of things, and becomes, in its whole existence, as that course brings it about, so too its whole organization—both in inner, psychic, and in outer respects—is constituted in such a way, answering to the totality, that every influence coming from the totality, whether it come from without or from the inner universal, calls forth its own determinate corresponding activity in the individual organization, or in the microcosm, and this so that it now, according to the latter’s own fundamental nature, leads precisely to such a certain determinate production that just that determinate objective is thereby represented by us. So that, although we constantly behold objects in our own soul, we nonetheless behold the actual objects as they are in themselves, because our inner representations become images of them, or counter-images to them, inasmuch as our inner life of consciousness—according to that inner harmony of its with the totality, when it (be it noted) is in its normal course—must each time bring forth, out of its own inner working, precisely that nerve-action, with corresponding representation-action, which produces just that representation which answers to the object. The individual organism, which contains within itself the real possibility of all possible representation-productions, is as it were calculated to work, at every point—that is, in every respect—in such accord or concordance with every influence coming from the side of the total, that the former each time produces precisely what the latter aims to call forth (as when an instrument, according to its own entire construction, renders—though in its own individual way—precisely the tone that is struck on another). We feel ourselves, however, in this not as related to mere counter-images, but as related to actual objects, because we here constantly feel our organism subjected to an affection which, coming from something other than ourselves, is what calls forth and compels that action and production of our own soul—so that the affection of our individual organism, or microcosm, distinguishes for us sensation from mere representation.

§ 4.

Philosophy is b) intelligent and rational cognizing. —The fundamental moments of cognition in their appearance as such. —Cognition as intelligent.

The individual life of consciousness, determined by the power of the objective, shows itself, insofar as it comes forward over against the objective, as that which is in itself free, carrying with it an inexhaustible possibility of acting in other ways than the way which the determining necessity each time brings with it. The necessity thus refers here to a freedom, and has such a freedom for its object, since it is precisely the in-itself-free (the in-itself-free imagination and reflection) that is bound by the necessity; and only thereby does cognition acquire the character of a cognizing, since only thereby does it show itself as an ascription of validity [Gyldighedstillæggelse]. [The true, too, comes forward as the valid and as that which is cognized in its validity only to the same degree as this free element, coming forward as such, then shows itself to be that which is determined and bound.]

But in the first natural cognizing, which forms itself of its own accord, and in which we on the whole comport ourselves as natural beings (cf. my *Psych.*, *ny Udarb.*, § 26), the opposition between the objective and the subjectivity, though it may show itself in particular cases, does not come forward in such a way that it wholly asserts itself as such. Cognition finds itself then, despite all the mediating element lying within it, at a first stage of immediacy, and the moments of cognition, though certainly present, are so lost in the cognizing as a whole that they do not come forward as such. But then neither does the true come forward for us in *its truth*, nor does it come to assert itself by its formally acknowledged validity.

In order for the true to attain such a higher governance, the individual life of consciousness lying on the side of the subjectivity must first come wholly forth into its freedom. And to this, too, the striving for cognition leads in its advance, in that we—whether by some other interest, or by mere desire to know [Videdrivt] and the higher life working itself forth through it—are moved to go beyond the immediately given, to seek other and more: either merely a) by looking further about us in the sphere opened to us, whereby not only the directing of the mind, that is, attention, becomes free, but also, as expectation sets in, the representation begins to find itself unbound; or else b) by asking after other and more than what is given in that sphere, because through it we find ourselves awakened to seek something such as that to which the given points—so that a spirit of inquiry [Randsagelsesaand] asserts itself, and scrutiny [Granskning]

or investigation [Efterforskning] comes forth, and now not only the representation, the imagination, but also the pursuit of relations and connections lying within it, or reflection, comes forward as such. —But the new that is now in this way formally sought is sought at the same time as the valid, and as answering to the investigation in such a way that that questioning can find itself satisfied; whereby one strives after a result by which the representing and pursuing that has become free—or has stepped forth into its freedom—can again be sufficiently determined and bound, with a necessity that is now also sought, and which, when found, will come to come forward as such.

But the necessity—together with the being-governed by, and being-at-home in, the power of the objective—that sets in in this way has then a different and freer character than that first immediate necessity. It now comes forward as necessity of understanding and reason [Forstands- og Fornuftenødvendighed], and we ourselves now show ourselves as beings of reason who ascribe validity because we acknowledge according to an express admission, assent, and approval grounded in insight; whereby the acknowledgment, or ascription of validity, too comes—stepping forth into its freedom—to show itself as such. For although at first it may be only new objects, of the same kind as those given in an immediate way, that are thus sought under a merely tracking observation, they must now not only show themselves to us as the ones we sought, but we must now also be assured that they are the right ones, and that we now objectify them to ourselves rightly, so that nothing else presents itself to us and is posited by us than the in-itself-valid, or that which *ought* to be posited. —But this then naturally has such a retroactive effect on what was earlier immediately assumed that it too can be drawn into the same consideration, so that *all* cognizing can become the object of a question as to its validity.

Cognition will in this way become one that we ourselves confirm in ourselves, in that we confirm ourselves in it, so that now the assurance too comes to show itself as such, and indeed as a potentiated assurance, or as an assurance of whose validity we are assured. —But certainly the uncertainty lying in the questioning may here too come forward in such a way that something doubting, dubitative, may set in, which is however overcome when a result is attained that becomes sufficiently satisfying.

Here, then, there emerges a properly mediated cognizing—mediated, namely, by thinking, and resting on thinking and the satisfaction of thinking—an intelligent cognizing, in the formation of which the fundamental demands originally lying in the pursuit of connection and relation that strives toward cognition, that is, in thinking itself (in the intelligence in the subject), are so in motion that it is in accordance with their satisfaction that insight, approval, and acknowledgment set in.

§ 5.

§ 6.

§ 7.

The Propaedeutic Concept of Philosophy and Its Exposition.

§ 8.

§ 9.

§ 10.

§ 11.

§ 12.

§ 13, a.

§ 13, b.

§ 14.

The Foundation of Philosophy and Its Work.

§ 15.

§ 16.

§ 17.

§ 18.

§ 19.

The Full Determination of the Concept of Philosophy.

§ 20.

Philosophy as a Member and Moment in the Whole Spiritual Life.

§ 21.